

Theatricality of Imperial Rome: Counterproductive Persecution of Free Speech

Prof. Daniel Schillinger

Directed Studies, History and Politics

Fall 2025

One might think that in Imperial Rome, actors restricted themselves to the theater. Tacitus, in the *Annals*, shines a light on the perversion of speech as traditional Roman politics adapt to autocratic power. The senate is a microcosm of political speech since it is where the emperor and the senators come together; in other words, the degree to which their dialogue is sincere shows how free political speech is. The stifling of free speech begins with violent tactics employed by the emperor. Senators are averse to engaging in free speech since it is criminalized. With no true political dialogue, what remains is a facade. Externally, Republican conventions are performed; privately, the emperor wields autocratic power. Paralleling the degradation of political discourse, politics becomes theatrical. With Tiberius the senate is performative in its display of devotion, and with Nero he himself is an actor more than an emperor. Nevertheless, the persecution of free speech which creates theatricality is counterproductive. Speech which is persecuted increases in value. Since theatrical politics exist because of the persecution of free thought, it undermines itself by elevating free expression. The theatricality of politics in Imperial Rome subjects free speech to persecution while elevating its value.

The stifling of free speech begins with persecution from the emperor. Tiberius, as he became emperor, “only showed signs of hesitation when he addressed the senate” (p. 36). The adverb “only” is crucial since it distinguishes Tiberius’ relation to the senate from any other. These “signs of hesitation” are interpreted by the senate as an opportunity for them to speak. This is a trick, “Tiberius had pretended to be hesitant...to detect what leading men were

thinking”(p. 36). There is no sense of cooperation between senate and emperor; Tiberius does not listen to the senate to understand but to “detect”: a verb with a connotation of surveillance. As a result, “every word, every look [Tiberius] twisted into some criminal significance”(p. 36). It is not only the opposition that is targeted, but “every word” is twisted; the content of the speech is irrelevant; Tiberius is forcing criminal meaning onto the words. His surveillance even extends beyond speech itself: “every look”, every facial expression, is also criminalized. Nero’s political persecution is much less subtle; he murders any political enemy he detects. Murdering his mother Agrippina (p. 317) and his half brother Britannicus (p. 291), Nero is erratic in his violence towards anyone who seems to get in his way. For Tiberius, any sort of free speech is criminalized, and for Nero, political oppositors are attacked violently. Both autocratic regimes sustain themselves on violence which stifles political discourse and freedom of thought.

Tiberius’ speech contradicts his own actions; he is deceptive. At Augustus’ funeral, Tiberius said that “a State which could rely on so many distinguished personages ought not to concentrate the supreme power in the hands of one man” (p. 39). By criticizing the concentration of power “in the hands of one man”, he is criticizing autocracy. How is this reconcilable with Tiberius’ own persecution of senators? It is not. His actions oppose what he proclaims – Tiberius endeavors to concentrate power in his sole hands. It is important to notice that Tacitus invokes Tiberius’ direct speech without using quotations, meaning that he is framing the dialogue purposefully. He constructs a clear juxtaposition of Tiberius’ speech and his actions; under this light, his speech becomes a blatant deception—Tiberius in speech is not Tiberius in action. Tacitus makes this clear: “[Tiberius] was determined to show no sign of his real feelings; his words became more and more equivocal and obscure” (p. 39). Tiberius’ real feelings, which can be deduced from his actions, are autocratic. Yet, he hides his intent underneath “equivocal and

obscure” language which makes it difficult for senators to pinpoint where Tiberius truly stands. His political discourse builds a persona that contradicts his true intentions.

The obscurity of the emperor’s speech forces senators to adore Tiberius: the play begins. With the precedent of Tiberius’ criminalization of speech, consider the position that senators are in when Tiberius speaks against autocracy: if a senator agrees, he is persecuted by Tiberius’ true intent; if a senator disagrees, he is persecuted for not supporting Tiberius. The lack of options places the senators in a trap, where the “chief fear of the senators was that they should be seen to understand [Tiberius] only too well” (p. 39). What it means for the senators to understand Tiberius “too well”, is that they know he is deceiving them. The senators fear that Tiberius notices that they are aware of his obscure tactics because that will only incite persecution against them. Their lack of options explains their response, “[the senators] poured forth a flood of tearful lamentations and prayer...making reverent gestures before Tiberius himself” (p. 39). The exuberant imagery of a “flood” of tears conveys the senators’ exaggerated reaction. The senators elevate Tiberius to a divine status by making “reverent gestures”, a fervent display of devotion. It is the only way to avoid agreeing or disagreeing with him while supporting him. Such an overwhelming display of emotion belongs in a theater rather than in politics. Yet, the senators must perform eccentric adoration for Tiberius; theatricality enters political space. The stifling of free speech pushes Roman politics towards theatricality, where the autocrat is the audience that must be pleased.

Nero as emperor becomes a theatrical performer in the political sphere. Nero cannot craft his own speeches. At Claudius’ funeral he gives a speech which was composed by Seneca; elder citizens note that Nero “was the first ruler to need borrowed eloquence” (p. 285). Nero is not different from an actor who is given a script, except that is an actor’s job, not an emperor’s.

Effective speech becomes a matter of appearance in an autocracy and is no longer a tool for the emperor. Even if Tiberius had been deceitful in his speech, he certainly was skilled in doing so: “Tiberius was a master at weighing out his words – he could express his thoughts forcibly, or he could be deliberately obscure”(p. 285). Speech was a central part of Tiberius’ rule; he was keenly aware of how he could advance his autocratic endeavor by speaking in certain ways. In Tiberius’ case he crafted his own performance; Nero is just the performer. Just like in theater where oratorical merit is attributed to the playwright, “Seneca put [speeches] in [Nero’s] mouth, to display his own talent or demonstrate his high-minded guidance” (p. 288). The terms “display” and “demonstrate” show the bastardization of speech as it becomes a spectacle. Describing Seneca as putting speeches in Nero’s mouth, makes a puppet out of Nero. The theatricality of Tiberius and Nero is different: with Tiberius, the political discourse was insincere; with Nero, the notion of sincerity is rendered unthinkable since his words are not even his. To have the emperor become hardly distinguishable from an actor on stage highlights the theatricality of political dynamics.

An autocrat’s persecution of speech is counterproductive since it gives free speech power. Cremutius is convicted for praising anti-Caesarian Brutus and Cassius, an act of free speech. As he defended himself in the senate, Tacitus noted the “grimness of Tiberius’ face as he listened” (p. 174). The attention to his facial expression implies the weight that the autocrat’s judgement has. Tiberius’ disapproval is no surprise since Cremutius criticizes the repression of thought; Cremutius says, “things unnoticed are forgotten; resentment confers status upon them” (p. 174). For Cremutius, it does not make sense for an autocrat to repress an idea, since attacking it means that it is threatening, which elevates its importance. Additionally, the theatricality which now characterizes the facade of the Roman Republic creates the opportunity for someone like

Cremutius to speak freely. That is why Cremutius says, “if I am condemned, people will remember me as well as Cassius and Brutus” (p. 175). Being condemned, the resentment towards his ideas will grant them status, making the attempt to silence him counterproductive.

A state which attacks free speech inevitably attacks itself. After Cremutius’ speech, the “senate ordered [Cremutius’] books to be burnt” (p.175). Nevertheless, the works survived and were republished later. For Tacitus this shows, “the stupidity of people who believe that today’s authority can destroy tomorrow’s memories” (p. 175). The attempt to destroy ideas counterproductively makes them proliferate; they attain a higher status due to their persecution. The aphoristic language comparing “today” and “tomorrow” gives this phrase a didactic purpose. Tacitus wants it to be clear that once something has been expressed, the autocrat’s action of repression has the opposite effect. Tacitus adds that what, “tyrannical conquerors...achieve is their own disrepute and the victims’ renown” (p. 175). By “tyrannical conquerors” he refers to the authority which claims to stifle free speech. Tacitus makes it clear that an authority which thwarts such speech, thwarts itself by elevating the speech which opposes it. The theatrical performance of Roman politics exists due to the persecution of genuine expression. Yet, the persecution of free political expression elevates the free expression itself. The theater Roman politics has become implies its own debasement as free speech is thwarted but elevated.

Tacitus’ *Annals* characterize the perversion of speech in Imperial Rome. With Tiberius, political discourse turns deceptive and free expression is criminalized. Theatricality becomes part of the political speech as the emperor-senate dynamic becomes performative with Tiberius and Nero becomes more of an actor than an emperor. Underneath this theater, free thought continues to be persecuted at the hands of the autocrat. Nevertheless, persecution of free expression is

counterproductive; it elevates the speech and ridicules the persecutor. Freedom of speech is thwarted as theatricality usurps politics, yet speech is also elevated as it debases authority.